CHAPTER 14

REGIONAL ASPIRATIONS

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:

Examine how democratic accommodation transformed regional aspirations from existential threats into federal strengths; analyze the constitutional and political trajectory of Jammu and Kashmir under Article 370, the Punjab crisis encompassing the Anandpur Sahib Resolution, Operation Blue Star, and the 1985 Rajiv Longowal Accord, and the multi-layered autonomy and anti-foreigner movements in the North-East including the Mizo Accord and the Assam Movement.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Democratic Accommodation of Diversity:** India rejected cultural homogenization, treating regional diversity not as an anti-national pathology but as an authentic expression of democratic pluralism mediated through federal dialogue.

• **Autonomy and Integration in Jammu and Kashmir:** Governed by the Instrument of Accession signed by Maharaja Hari Singh and codified under Article 370, Kashmir experienced decades of political friction, disputed elections, and cross-border militancy after 1989.

• **The Punjab Tragedy and Peace Accord:** Emerging from the 1973 Anandpur Sahib Resolution, Sikh regionalism was hijacked by violent extremists, leading to Operation Blue Star (June 1984), the assassination of Indira Gandhi, anti-Sikh violence, and the 1985 Rajiv Gandhi - Longowal Accord.

• **North-Eastern Reorganisation and Accords:** Faced three interrelated demands: autonomy, secessionism, and anti-foreigner agitations, resolved through peace accords such as the Mizo Accord of 1986 and the 1985 Assam Accord.

ESSENTIAL CONSTITUTIONAL ARTICLES & THEORIES

$$\text{Democratic Accommodation} \iff \text{National Unity} + \text{Regional Autonomy} \to \text{Asymmetric Federalism}$$

Indian Constitutional Philosophy Accommodating Diversity

$$\text{Kashmir Accession (October 1947)} \iff \text{Maharaja Hari Singh Accession} \to \text{Special Status under Article 370}$$

Constitutional Framework of Jammu and Kashmir's Integration

$$\text{Punjab Crisis Settlement} \iff \text{Operation Blue Star (June 1984)} \longrightarrow \text{Rajiv Gandhi - Longowal Accord (1985)}$$

Transition from Violent Insurgency to Democratic Reconciliation

$$\text{Northeast Peace Accords} \iff \{\text{Assam Accord (1985: AASU)}, \quad \text{Mizo Accord (1986: Laldenga)}\}$$

Resolution of Sub-National Movements via Constitutional Settlement

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Do not view regional aspirations as inherently secessionist or anti-national; democratic theory recognizes regional assertion as a normal part of federal democratic politics.

• **Alert:** Remember that Article 370 gave Jammu and Kashmir greater autonomy than other states, requiring the concurrence of the state government on central legislation outside defense, foreign affairs, and communications.

• **Alert:** Avoid writing that the Assam Movement of 1979 to 1985 was directed against Indian citizens from other states; it was explicitly launched against undocumented foreign immigrants from Bangladesh.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. State the fundamental Indian approach toward accommodating regional aspirations and cultural diversity. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Unity in Diversity:** Unlike European nation-states that enforced linguistic homogeneity, India embraced regional identities and linguistic diversity as natural constituents of a shared nationhood. **[1 Mark]**

• **Democratic Negotiation:** Regional demands for autonomy are resolved through constitutional dialogue, federal power-sharing, and peace accords rather than military suppression. **[1 Mark]**

2. Under what historical circumstances did Maharaja Hari Singh sign the Instrument of Accession with India in October 1947? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Tribal Infiltration from Pakistan:** Armed tribal infiltrators led by Pakistani military officers invaded Kashmir to forcibly capture Srinagar. **[1 Mark]**

• **Signing for Military Defense:** Unable to resist the invasion, the Maharaja appealed to India for military assistance and signed the Instrument of Accession on 26 October 1947, acceding to the Indian Union. **[1 Mark]**

3. Trace the key demands articulated in the Anandpur Sahib Resolution of 1973 adopted by the Shiromani Akali Dal. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Greater Federal Autonomy:** Demanded a radical restructuring of center-state relations, insisting that the central government's jurisdiction should be confined solely to defense, foreign affairs, communications, and currency. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Cultural Assertion and Water Rights:** Called for the protection of Sikh cultural identity, linguistic rights, transfer of Chandigarh exclusively to Punjab, and an equitable distribution of river waters. **[1.5 Marks]**

4. What was 'Operation Blue Star'? Describe its traumatic consequences and the subsequent peace accord. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Operation Blue Star (June 1984):** A major military operation launched by the Indian Army to flush out armed Sikh militants who had fortified themselves inside the Golden Temple complex in Amritsar. **[1 Mark]**

• **Traumatic Aftermath:** Deeply wounded Sikh religious sentiments, leading directly to the assassination of Prime Minister Indira Gandhi on 31 October 1984 and horrific anti-Sikh violence across Delhi. **[1 Mark]**

• **Punjab Accord (July 1985):** Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi and Akali leader Harchand Singh Longowal signed the Punjab Accord, agreeing to transfer Chandigarh to Punjab and resolve river water disputes peacefully. **[1 Mark]**

5. Explain how the secessionist insurgency in Mizoram was brought to a peaceful democratic end in 1986. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Famine Neglect and Insurgency:** Severe famine in 1959 caused public fury over Assam government neglect, leading Laldenga to form the Mizo National Front (MNF) and wage a two-decade armed insurgency for an independent Mizoram. **[1 Mark]**

• **Mizo Peace Accord (1986):** In 1986, Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi and Laldenga signed a historic peace accord under which the MNF surrendered all weapons and ended secessionist violence. **[1 Mark]**

• **Statehood and Democratic Politics:** Mizoram was granted full statehood with special constitutional protections, and Laldenga took office as Chief Minister after winning democratic elections. **[1 Mark]**

6. Analyze the causes, nature, and outcomes of the Assam Movement against undocumented immigrants from 1979 to 1985. **[Score: 4 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Demographic Anxieties:** Indigenous Assamese feared that massive demographic influx from Bangladesh would reduce them to a cultural, linguistic, and political minority in their own homeland. **[1 Mark]**

• **Leadership and Mobilization:** Led by the All Assam Students Union (AASU) and the All Assam Gana Sangram Parishad (AAGSP), launching mass strikes, blockades of oil pipelines, and non-violent protests. **[1 Mark]**

• **The Assam Accord (1985):** Signed on 15 August 1985 between Rajiv Gandhi and AASU leaders, agreeing that undocumented migrants who entered Assam after 24 March 1971 would be identified and deported. **[1 Mark]**

• **Electoral Transition:** AASU and movement leaders organized into a regional political party, the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP), winning state assembly elections in December 1985. **[1 Mark]**

7. Highlight three lessons for democratic governance derived from the handling of regional movements in India. **[Score: 3 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Regional Aspirations are Democratic Expressions:** Regional demands must not be viewed automatically as treason; they reflect legitimate federal desires for self-governance and cultural dignity. **[1 Mark]**

• **Primacy of Political Negotiation:** Military suppression cannot resolve political grievances; lasting solutions require dialogue, patience, and political accommodation. **[1 Mark]**

• **Power Sharing and Asymmetric Federalism:** Special provisions (such as Article 371 and the Sixth Schedule) allow diverse cultural groups to manage their local affairs within a united nation. **[1 Mark]**